$100M SCALING ROADMAP

▶ STAGE 0: IMPROVISE ◀



A PERSONALIZED GUIDE FROM

ACQUISITION.COM

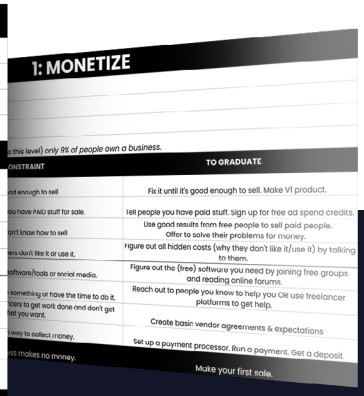

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YOU ARE HERE

STAGE 0: IMPROVISE

▼

0: IMPROVISE		
HEADCOUNT	NA	
YOUR ROLE	RESEARCHER	
LEADERSHIP STRUCTURE	Just you.	
# OF COMPANIES HERE	NA...you're not a company yet.	
	CONSTRAINT	**TO GRADUATE**
PRODUCT	You have nothing to sell.	Make something FREE to give away
MARKETING	No one knows about your stuff.	Tell people you have FREE stuff.
SALES	You don't know how to sell	Get people to try it for free
CUSTOMER SERVICE	No customers to service.	Service your free customers.
INFORMATION TECH (IT)	You have no tech.	Get a Computer. Internet. Microphone. Phone. Email.
RECRUITING	You don't know how to work.	You recruit yourself to work.
HUMAN RESOURCES (HR)	You're unprotected.	Create an entity to separate your personal assets from your business assets.
FINANCE	Your personal money is the business's money.	Get a business bank account. Put money in. Write off start up expenses to save on taxes.
Bottom line	Nothing is happening.	Get people to try your stuff for free.



0. IMPROVISE

1. MONETIZE
2. ADVERTISE
3. STABILIZE
4. PRIORITIZE
5. PRODUCTIZE
6. OPTIMIZE
7. CATEGORIZE
8. SPECIALIZE
9. CAPITALIZE

STAGE 0: IMPROVISE

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WATCH THIS FIRST

"START HERE"



THIS VIDEO EXPLAINS THE ENTIRE $100M SCALING ROADMAP. THIS INCLUDES:

- The methodology
- The differences between stages
- Repeat themes to be aware of
- How to get the most out of your business

GOT IT? LET'S START SCALING ▶▶▶

YOUR STAGE

STAGE 0

IMPROVISE



THIS VIDEO PROVIDES AN IN-DEPTH LOOK AT THE CONSTRAINTS & SOLUTIONS AT **STAGE 0**

YOUR ROLE

Researcher

HEADCOUNT

N/A

BOTTOM LINE

Nothing is happening

GRADUATE BY

Get people to try your stuff for free

WHEN YOU HIT "STAGE 0: IMPROVISE"

Stage 0 is like being at the very beginning of building a house - you don't even have the tools or materials yet, but you're ready to start. At this stage, you're just one person with an idea, but no actual business. The goal is simple: get people to try your stuff for free.

Think of it like being a brand new cook who wants to open a restaurant someday. Before charging anyone money, you need to practice cooking and have people taste your food to see if it's any good. That's what Stage 0 is all about - testing things out without asking for money.

HERE'S WHAT YOU NEED TO FOCUS ON AT STAGE 0:

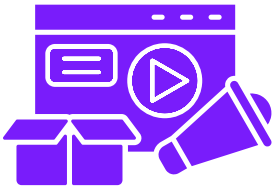
- Product
- Marketing
- Sales
- Customer Service
- Technology
- Basic Setup





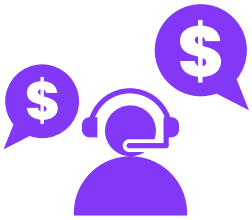
Product

You need to make something you can give away for free. It could be a service (like helping someone with their computer), information (like teaching someone how to do something), or an actual product. The important thing is that it's free so people will try it.



Marketing

You need to tell people about your free stuff. The easiest way is to start with people you know - friends, family, people you've emailed before, or people who follow you on social media. You just need to let them know you have something free that might help them.



Sales

Since you don't know how to sell yet, you're just asking people to try your free stuff. When they try it, you ask them what they think and what would make it better. This helps you learn what people actually want.



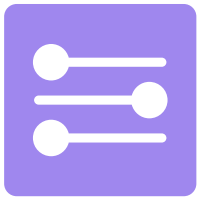
Customer Service

You need to take really good care of the people who try your free stuff. Answer their questions quickly, help them use what you gave them, and be super nice - even though they aren't paying. These people are helping you learn what works and what doesn't.



Technology

You just need the basics—a computer, internet connection, phone, and email address. Nothing fancy. Think of these as your basic tools, like a hammer and screwdriver when building a house.



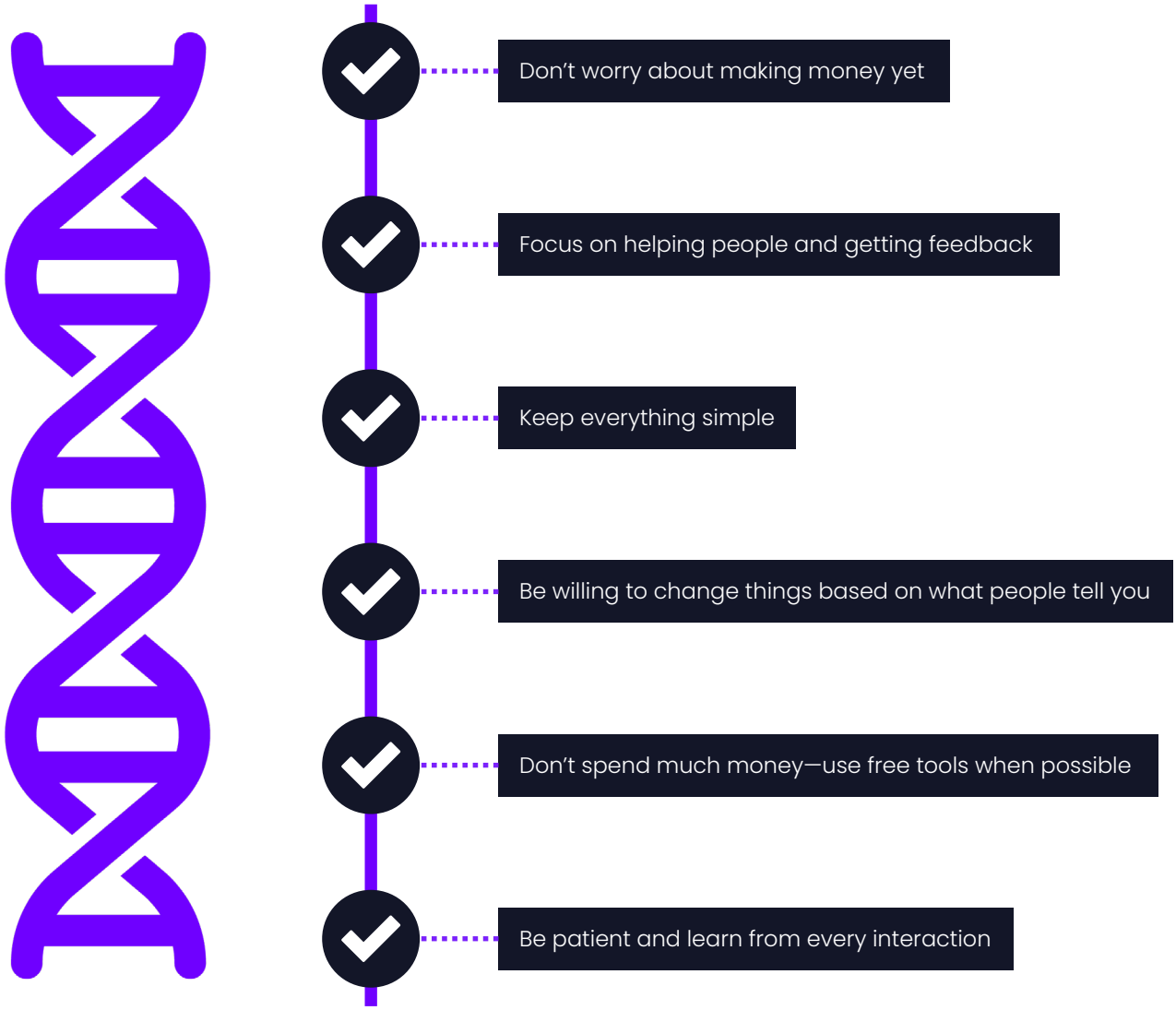
Basic Setup

You need to protect yourself by creating a business entity (like an LLC) to keep your personal money separate from business money. You'll also need a business bank account and to keep track of any money you spend on your business since you can write these off on taxes.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE AT STAGE 0

The most important thing at Stage 0 is to find out if people actually want what you're offering. It's like cooking for friends before opening a restaurant - you want honest feedback about whether your food is good and what would make it better.

SOME KEY THINGS TO REMEMBER:



THE MAIN GOAL IS TO GET ENOUGH PEOPLE TO TRY YOUR FREE STUFF AND LIKE IT.

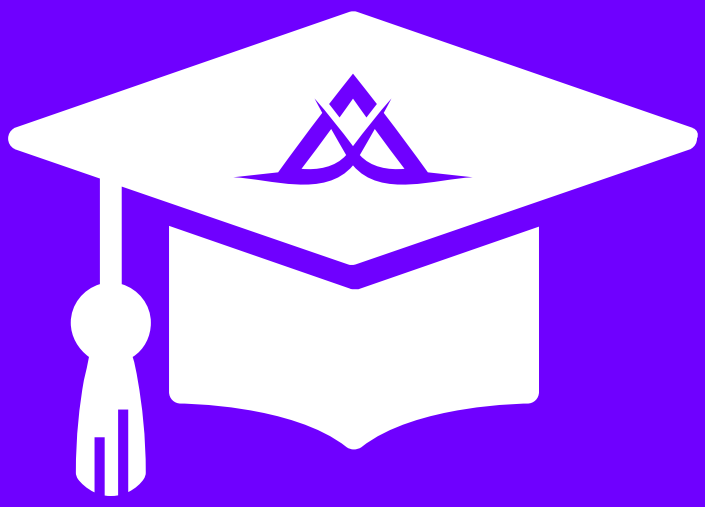
Once people are saying good things about what you offer and coming back for more, you know you're ready to move to Stage 1, where you'll start charging money.

THINK OF STAGE 0 AS PRACTICE MODE OR THE TUTORIAL LEVEL IN A VIDEO GAME.

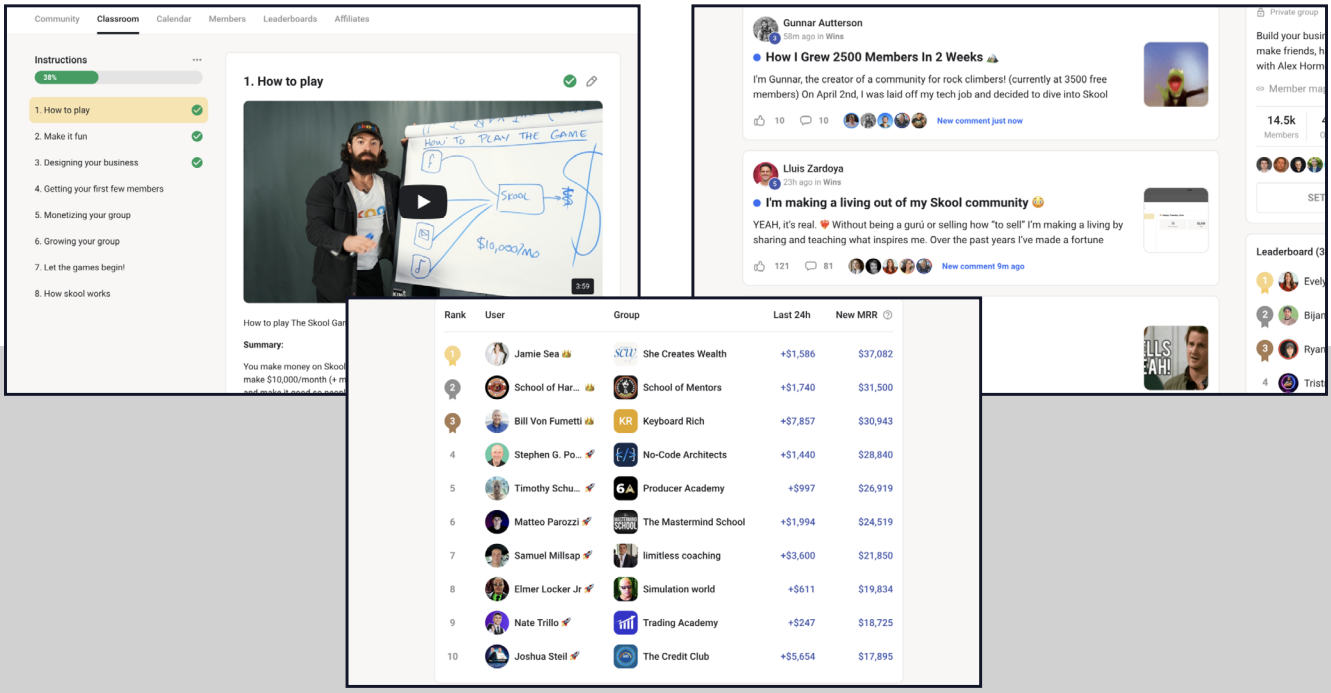
You're learning the basic moves and getting comfortable before the real game begins. It might feel slow or frustrating at times, but this foundation is super important for building a successful business later.

THE SIGN THAT YOU'RE READY TO GRADUATE FROM STAGE 0 IS SIMPLE:

People are actually using your free stuff and finding it helpful. When that happens, you can start thinking about charging money and moving to Stage 1.



THE FASTEST WAY TO START AN ONLINE BUSINESS



Would you like the fastest way to start an online business? Meet Skool. Skool is an online platform for building a group about whatever you want. Right now 1 out of 2 people who start a paid community on Skool make money. You can get started for free today.

Start For Free

skool.com/GAMES

THIS IS WHAT'S COMING NEXT...



STAGE 1: MONETIZE

STAGE 1: MONETIZE

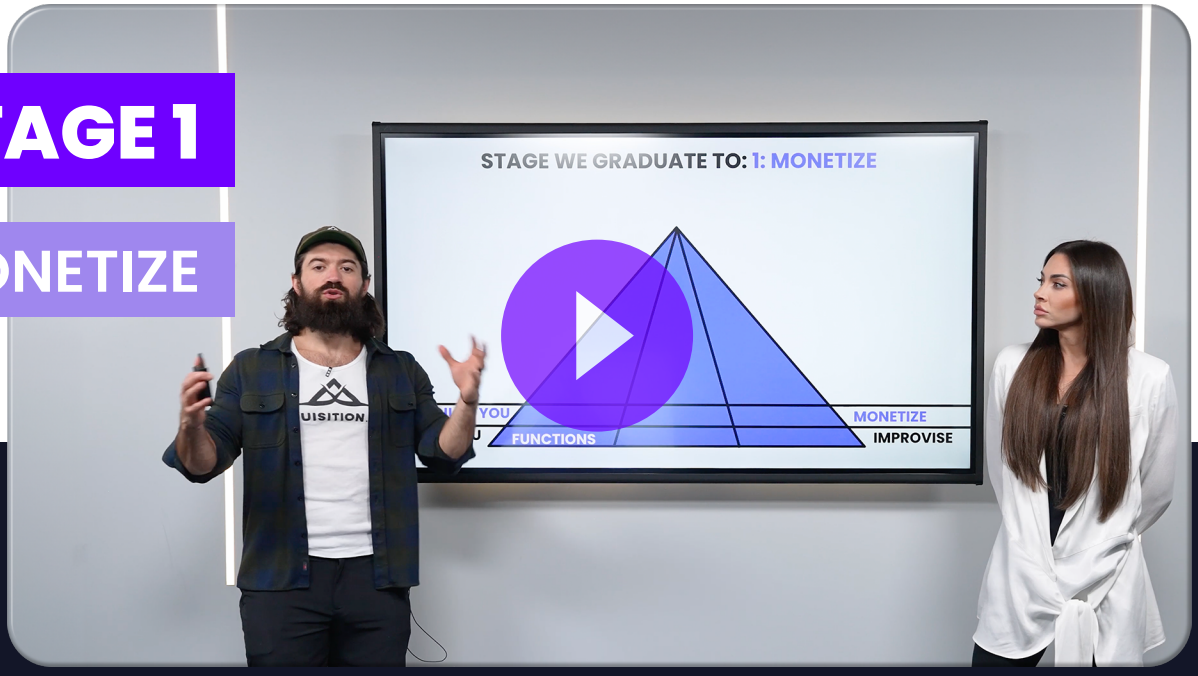
HEADCOUNT	1
YOUR ROLE	STARTER
LEADERSHIP STRUCTURE	*Still* Just you.
# OF COMPANIES HERE	30,000,000 (100% achieve this level) *only 9% of people own a business.*

	CONSTRAINT	TO GRADUATE
PRODUCT	Not good enough to sell	Fix it until it's good enough to sell. Make V1 product.
MARKETING	No one knows you have PAID stuff for sale.	Tell people you have paid stuff. Sign up for free ad spend credits.
SALES	You *still* don't know how to sell	Use good results from free people to sell paid people. Offer to solve their problems for money.
CUSTOMER SERVICE	Free customers don't like it or use it.	Figure out all hidden costs (why they don't like it/use it) by talking to them.
INFORMATION TECH (IT)	You have no basic software/tools or social media.	Figure out the (free) software you need by joining free groups and reading online forums.
RECRUITING	You don't know how to do something or have the time to do it.	Reach out to people you know to help you OR use freelancer platforms to get help.
HUMAN RESOURCES (HR)	You pay money to freelancers to get work done and don't get what you want.	Create basic vendor agreements & expectations
FINANCE	You have no way to collect money.	Set up a payment processor. Run a payment. Get a deposit.
Bottom line	Your business makes no money.	Make your first sale.

YOUR STAGE

STAGE 1

MONETIZE



THIS VIDEO PROVIDES AN IN-DEPTH LOOK AT THE CONSTRAINTS & SOLUTIONS AT **STAGE 1**

YOUR ROLE	HEADCOUNT	BOTTOM LINE	GRADUATE BY
Starter	1	Your business makes no money	Make your first sale

WHEN YOU HIT "STAGE 1: MONETIZE"

Welcome to Stage 1: The "Monetize" stage! You've graduated from giving stuff away for free, and now it's time to start making actual money. Think of this like moving from cooking free meals for friends to opening a small food stand where people actually pay for your food.

THE BIG PICTURE:

At this stage, you're still just one person, but now you're what we call a "starter" - someone who's starting to turn their idea into a real business. About 30 million people reach this stage, but only 9% of people in the United States actually own a business. It's like being in the kitchen by yourself, learning to cook and serve customers at the same time.

- **Your Main Challenge: Product**
- **Marketing Challenges**
- **Sales Challenges**
- **Customer Service**
- **Technology Needs**
- **Getting Help**
- **Managing Money**
- **Protecting Yourself**
- **The Human Side**

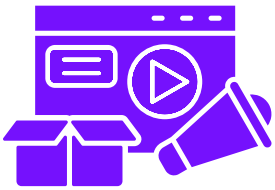




Your Main Challenge: Product

Your biggest problem right now is that your product or service isn't quite good enough for people to pay for yet. Maybe your food tastes good, but the portions are messy, or maybe your computer repair service works but takes too long. You need to fix these issues until people think, "Yes, this is worth paying for!"

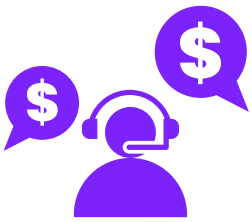
The key is to make what we call a "Version 1" or "V1" product. This doesn't mean it has to be perfect - it just needs to be good enough that people will pay for it. Think of it like making a sandwich that's good enough to sell at a food truck, even if it's not fancy restaurant quality yet.



Marketing Challenges

Now comes a tricky part - telling people you're charging money for something that used to be free. It's like telling your friends who used to get free sandwiches that now they need to pay. You need to:

- Let people know you're selling something
- Explain why it's worth paying for
- Sign up for free advertising credits on platforms like Google or Facebook
- Show how your paid version is better than the free one was



Sales Challenges

You probably don't know much about selling yet, and that's okay! The best approach is to:

- Use results from your free customers as proof ("Look how much this helped them!")
- Talk to people about their problems and show how you can solve them
- Start with people who already liked your free stuff
- Be honest about what you're offering and what it costs

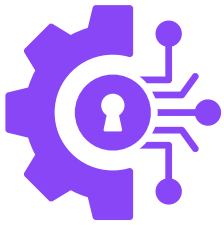


Customer Service

Your free customers helped you learn, but paying customers are different. They:

- Have higher expectations
- Are more likely to complain
- Need more attention
- Want better results

Your job is to figure out why people might not like or use your product. Maybe your computer repair service takes too long, or maybe your sandwich packaging leaks. You need to find these "hidden costs" - things that make customers unhappy even if they don't tell you directly.



Technology Needs

You probably can't afford fancy software yet, but you can:

- Join free online groups to learn what tools others use
- Read forums about your industry
- Use free trials of basic software
- Start with free tools like Google's business tools



Getting Help

You're going to realize you can't do everything yourself. When this happens:

- Reach out to people you know who might help
- Use websites like Upwork or Fiverr to find freelancers
- Start small with part-time help
- Be clear about what you need done



Managing Money

This is crucial—you need to:

- Set up a way to collect payments (like Square or PayPal)
- Actually run a real payment through your system
- Get your first paying customer's money into your bank account
- Keep track of who has paid and who hasn't



Protecting Yourself

When money starts flowing, you need to:

- Create basic agreements with anyone helping you
- Set clear expectations with freelancers
- Get everything in writing
- Make sure you understand what you're agreeing to



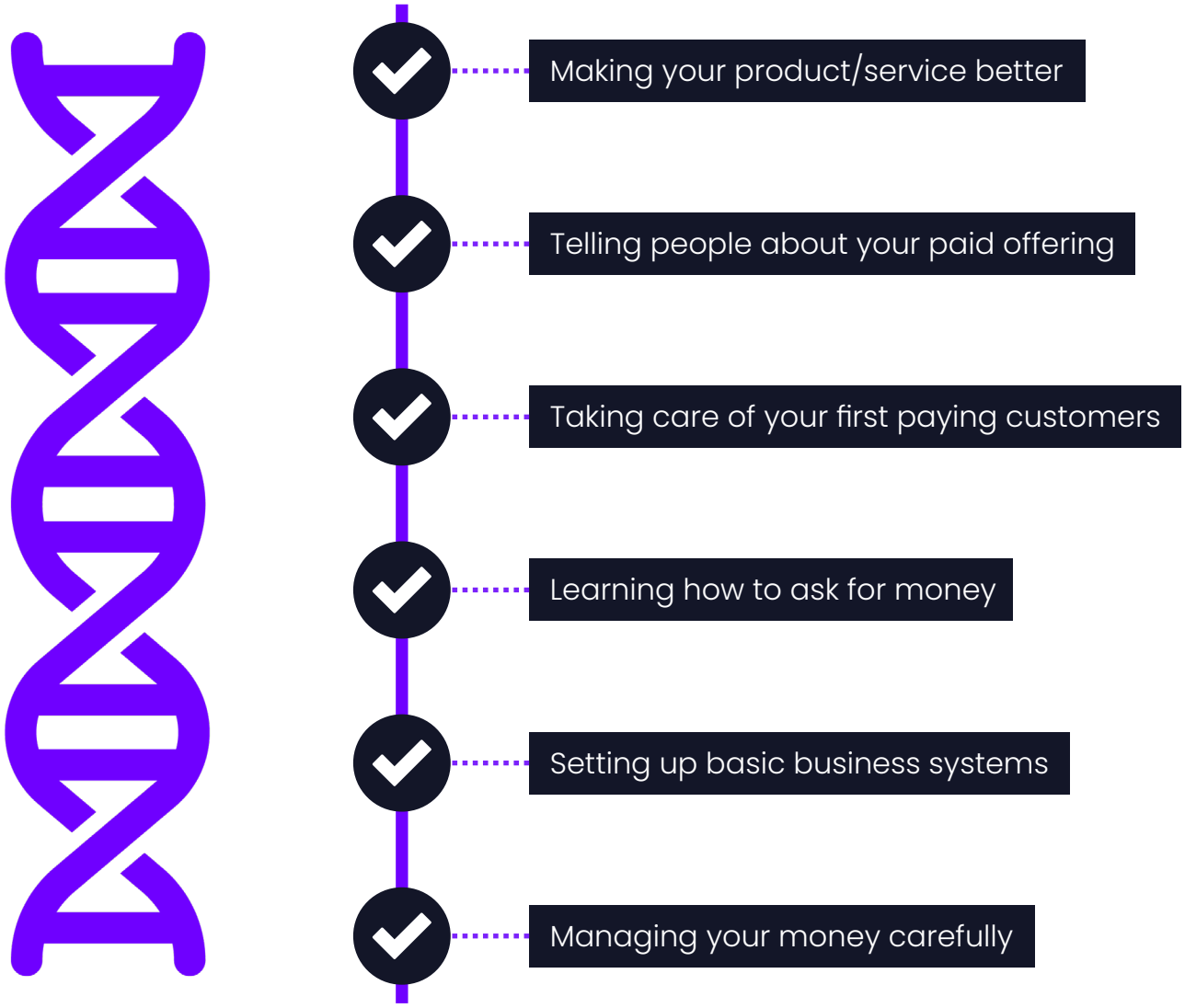
The Human Side

During this stage, you'll feel:

- Nervous about charging money
- Worried about whether people will pay
- Excited when you get your first sale
- Overwhelmed by all the new things to learn
- Proud when someone says yes to paying

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE AT STAGE 1

YOUR DAILY FOCUS SHOULD BE:



THE SECRET TO SUCCESS

SIGNS YOU'RE DOING IT RIGHT

- People are actually paying you money
- Customers are engaged
- You're learning from mistakes
- Your systems are simple but working
- You're keeping track of money
- You're starting to understand what customers want

SIGNS YOU NEED MORE WORK

- People won't pay your prices
- Customers are unhappy
- You're losing track of payments
- Things feel chaotic
- You're still doing everything for free

THE BIG GOAL:

Your main goal in Stage 1 is simple but crucial: make your first sale. Not just one sale, but consistent first sales to different customers. This proves that people will actually pay for what you're offering.

GRADUATING FROM STAGE 1

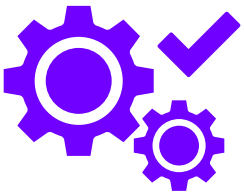
YOU'LL KNOW YOU'RE READY TO MOVE TO STAGE 2 WHEN:



YOU'RE CONSISTENTLY MAKING SALES



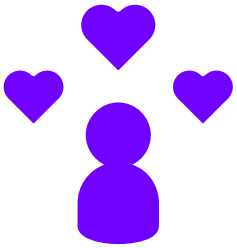
PEOPLE ARE WILLING TO PAY YOUR PRICES



YOU HAVE BASIC SYSTEMS IN PLACE



YOU'RE KEEPING TRACK OF MONEY



YOU UNDERSTAND WHAT CUSTOMERS WANT



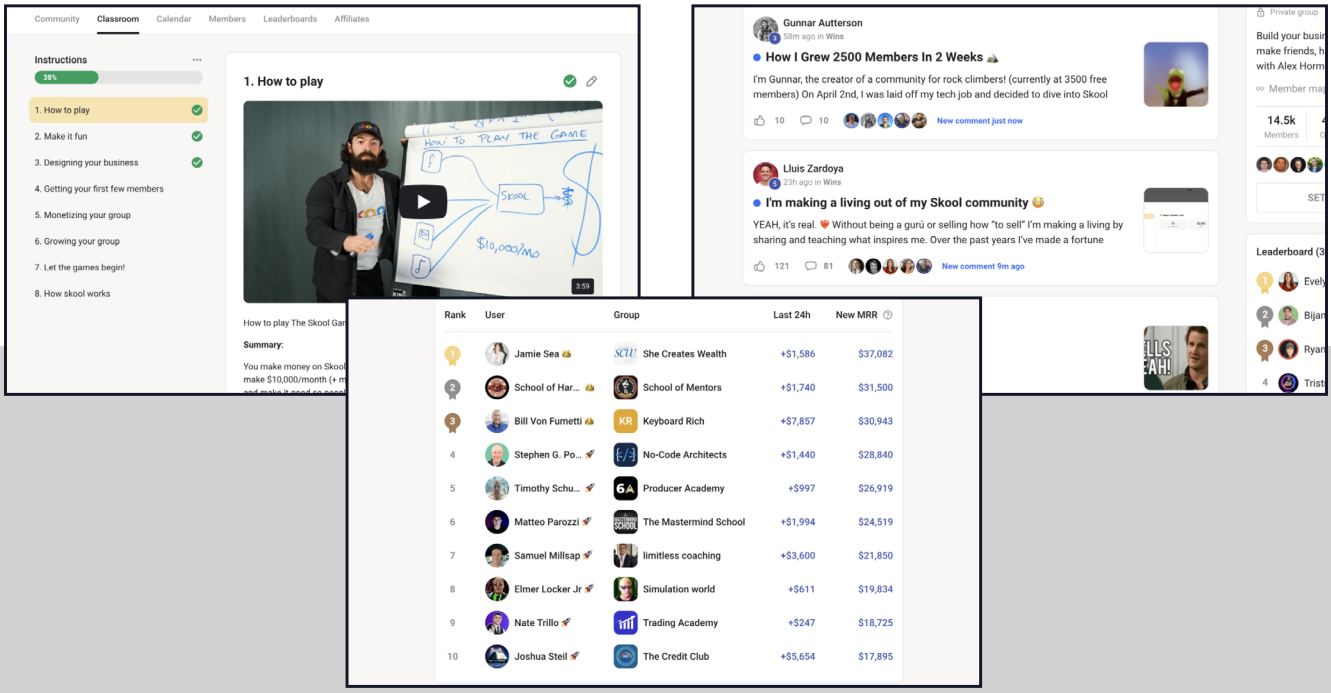
YOU'RE READY TO START ADVERTISING

REMEMBER

Stage 1 is all about that crucial shift from free to paid. It's about proving that you can create something people will actually pay for. Don't rush it—this foundation is crucial for everything that comes next in your business journey.

This stage can feel scary and uncomfortable, but it's where real businesses are born. Take it one step at a time, celebrate each sale, and learn from every mistake. You're not just selling something now - you're becoming a real business owner.

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